rudderless. On the other hand, the Chinese had been through some desperate fighting, first with the Japanese and then amongst themselves. Subsequently, the PLA had been involved in a protracted war with the dominant military power at the time, the United States, as they fought it out in the mountains of the Korean peninsula. They had emerged from the clash battered and bruised, but had absorbed the lessons of modern post-World War II combat in terms of operational manoeuvrability. When the time came, Indian commanders, unlike the Chinese, showed themselves to be flat-footed and unimaginative and simply did not know what to do once the enemy went on the offensive.

To understand what happened, it is imperative that we try and get as close to the bone as possible. At times the truth is not palatable, but it needs to be told. Shortage of ammunition and obsolete weapon systems played a role but they were not the defining factors in a conflict that was simply not fought by the Indians as a strong unit. Those who stood their ground and fought extracted a heavy toll from the Chinese who themselves were an army fighting out on a limb. Those who tried to get away were tackled piecemeal by the PLA. The Indian Army allowed the Chinese to bring overwhelming force into play against scattered positions, and mow them down ruthlessly. Therefore, it is also absolutely vital to shake off the traditional Indian indifference towards history so that the real problem is understood in its bare essence.

The Sino-Indian clash in 1962 was the culmination of many factors and many bit players had a role to play in it. At the centre of it all were the Tibetans, but the full cast includes the Chinese, Mongols, Russians, British, Nepalese, Bhutanese, Sikhs, Ladakhis, even the Americans and of course the Indians. At a time when the rest of the world was exhausted from the Second World War and attention was focused on the Cold War, Mao pulled off one of the greatest real estate coups of all time. It was a masterstroke in geopolitical manoeuvring. That India took the brunt of it was partly due to her own inability to think long term. In the end, even though the cast of villains can be long, we only had ourselves to blame. Hopefully, we shall not make the same mistake twice.

## THE INDIAN SUBCONTINENT

The Indian subcontinent is a distinct geographical entity with clearly demarcated and defensible borders. The region can be divided into four